

“Gotta Catch ‘Em All!” Pokémon, Cultural Practice and Object Networks

The Pokémon franchise is a networked collection of heterogeneous elements (manga, gaming, toys, anime) that is also constitutive of new knowledge around both consumerism and commodification. This paper explores how the elements of this franchise, from the brand, to the various media platforms, to the Pokémon trainers, to the pocket monsters themselves as well as the designers and the consumers function as objects in the construction of a social network. In so doing it seeks to understand not only how the franchise functions but also how the objects in this franchise (particularly the nonhuman Pokémon creatures and trainers) work in tandem to connect audiences to very specifically Japanese ideas of the “national imagination” (folklore, spiritualism, the supernatural) and environmental concerns (biodiversity, the struggle between conservation and containment) through the larger consumerist framework of acquisition and play structured as cultural practice.

Heads and Tails: An Analysis of Visual Signals in Cats

Communication between individuals of the same species is essential in their interactions to regulate their proximities and distances. Communication includes exchanges of more or less complex visual signals. We observed a total of 254 cat–cat interactions within a sample of 29 cats and attempted to decipher the most significant features of a visual configuration involving the combination of tail and ear positions in interactions between cats. Although the tail is a conspicuous feature for human observers, we demonstrate that ear positions of the cats in dyadic interactions with other cats are the best predictor of the outcomes of these interactions. However, in cat–human interactions, the cat most often approached with its tail up prior to rubbing itself against the human. The results are important for a better understanding of cats' perceptions of humans, and will help to promote cat welfare.

The Ethics of AI in Games

Video games are one of the richest and most popular forms of human-computer interaction. Their role is critical for our understanding of human behaviour and affect at large scale. As artificial intelligence tools are gradually adopted by the game industry a series of ethical concerns arise. Motivated by the lack of a comprehensive review of the ethics of AI as applied to games, we survey the current state of the art in this area and discuss ethical considerations of these systems from the holistic perspective of the affective loop. Through this cycle, we look at the ethical challenges AI faces in games. Elicitation is about AI influencing players' emotions, raising questions about what's acceptable. Monitoring involves tracking players, balancing privacy with safety. Detection is how AI changes the game based on player actions, bringing up concerns about transparency and control.

German-Japanese Relations from Meiji to Heisei

Scholars have debated for decades whether there has ever been any meaningful partnership between Germany and Japan before the start of second world war. A minority of specialists rejects the idea and points to various diplomatic breaches between both countries. Examples include Germany opposing Japan in 1895, Japan taking over German leasehold in China in 1914, and Germany making a deal with the Soviet Union in 1939, which undermined its earlier anti-communist alliance with Japan. Another reason was the mistaken belief in a global conspiracy between Berlin and Tokyo. This idea mainly resulted from German-Japanese-Italian propaganda and the Allies' own anti-Axis messaging. In the early 1940s, both sides depicted the Berlin-Rome-Tokyo alliance as a strong, anti-democratic "fascist" bloc. After clearing the smokescreen of wartime verbiage, however, scholars have questioned the actual degree of solidarity and depth of the Axis agreements.